Getting Mom's Money Questions Ready for a Professional

The family's part, in order: nine actions, with a line for who does each and by when.

The goal: you can hand a professional a clear, dated picture of what Mom's care costs, what is paying for it, the money decisions your family has made or is considering, and the questions you need answered.

Share the list. Put a name and a day next to each action, and tick it when it's done. The order is for your family's tasks only; it says nothing about the order of any financial step.

ACTION	WHO	BY WHEN	DONE
1. Write down what Mom's care costs each month, from the latest bill.			
2. Write down what comes in for her each month and which accounts the rest is paid from. Use the statements, and don't estimate.			
3. List her outstanding debts and regular expenses, and any home or personal expense that is coming up.			
4. Pull out her insurance policies, any annuity contract, her retirement account statements and the paperwork for any burial or funeral arrangement. This is only gathering: list what you found and what you couldn't find.			
5. List any gift, repayment, transfer, sale or account change already made, with the date and who was involved, as best you know.			
6. List every money decision the family is talking about, and mark each one “being discussed.”			
7. Write down what you've been told about what has to be spent or moved, with who said it, each as a question.			
8. Put the statements, receipts, contracts and other papers in one place, and add each new one as it arrives.			
9. Next to each open question, write who it may go to: your Medicaid planner, an elder law attorney, or a licensed insurance or financial professional. Then hand the whole picture to your Medicaid planner for review.			

You're done when

What Mom's care costs, what is paying for it, the money decisions made and being discussed, and your questions are all written down, the papers are in one place, and the whole picture has been handed over for review. What comes after that isn't on this list: the review itself, any strategy agreed with the professionals, the order of any financial action, and carrying it out with them. None of that is the family's to do alone.

If it doesn't go smoothly

- Don't fill a gap by guessing. “Can't find it” and “not sure of the date” are finished lines.
- If two relatives remember something differently, write both versions down.
- If a new idea about Mom's money comes up partway through, add it to the “being discussed” list, so it reaches your Medicaid planner with the others.

What this plan doesn't do

It organizes your family's part: facts, papers and questions for a professional's review. It doesn't say what has to be spent, approve any transaction, or put any financial action in order, and finishing it doesn't determine anything about Medicaid eligibility. Rules vary by state. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice.

Ready for the next step?

Your family's part is in order: the costs, the decisions and the questions. The planning interview is the next step. Answer its questions about your family's situation and it gives you a free planning report you can bring to your Medicaid planner.

Get Your Free Planning Report ›